

HEALING FROM TRAUMA

A Workbook for Teens Ages 13-18

You survived something hard.
This workbook helps you heal.

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IMPORTANT: This workbook is not therapy. If you are in crisis:

Call 988 | Text HOME to 741741 | Tell a trusted adult

WHAT IS TRAUMA?

Trauma is what happens INSIDE you after something bad happens.

It's not about what happened being 'bad enough.' If it affected you, it counts.

Trauma can come from:

- Abuse (physical, emotional, sexual)
- Neglect or abandonment
- Bullying or cyberbullying
- Witnessing violence
- Loss of someone you love
- Accidents or medical trauma
- Natural disasters
- Community violence
- Divorce or family chaos
- Anything that made you feel unsafe or helpless

YOUR EXPERIENCE IS VALID. You don't need to compare your pain to others.

HOW TRAUMA AFFECTS YOUR BRAIN & BODY

After trauma, your brain gets stuck in 'survival mode.' This causes:

BRAIN: Trouble concentrating, memory gaps, nightmares, flashbacks

BODY: Stomachaches, headaches, muscle tension, fatigue, startle response

EMOTIONS: Anger outbursts, numbness, anxiety, sadness, shame, mood swings

BEHAVIOR: Isolation, risk-taking, sleep changes, avoiding reminders

RELATIONSHIPS Trust issues, pushing people away, people-pleasing

IMPORTANT: These are NORMAL responses to ABNORMAL events.

Your brain is trying to protect you. It just needs help knowing you're safe now.

AM I SAFE NOW? (Safety Assessment)

Before healing can start, you need to feel safe. Let's check:

- ☐ Am I physically safe right now? (not being hurt)
- ☐ Do I have a safe place to sleep?
- ☐ Is there at least ONE adult I can trust?
- ☐ Am I still in contact with the person who hurt me?
- ☐ Do I have basic needs met (food, shelter, safety)?
- ☐ Am I currently hurting myself?

If you answered NO to safety questions or YES to being hurt:

TELL SOMEONE. A teacher, counselor, coach, or call: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453

My safe people right now:

1. Name: _____ How to reach them: _____
2. Name: _____ How to reach them: _____
3. Name: _____ How to reach them: _____

MY WINDOW OF TOLERANCE

Your 'window of tolerance' is where you feel okay - not too hyped, not too numb.

HYPERAROUSAL (above the window):

WINDOW OF TOLERANCE

(calm enough to think, feel, and cope)

HYPOAROUSAL (below the window):

Numbness, spacing out, exhaustion, disconnected, can't feel anything

Right now, I usually spend time:

- ☐ Above (hyper - too activated)
- ☐ In the window (mostly okay)
- ☐ Below (hypo - shut down)

Things that push me OUT of my window:

GROUNDING TECHNIQUES FOR TEENS

When you're triggered or dissociating, these bring you back to NOW:

5-4-3-2-1 TECHNIQUE:

- 5 things you can SEE
- 4 things you can TOUCH
- 3 things you can HEAR
- 2 things you can SMELL
- 1 thing you can TASTE

ICE CUBE TECHNIQUE:

Hold ice in your hands. Focus on the cold. It brings you to present.

MUSIC GROUNDING:

Put on a song you love. Focus on every instrument, every word.

MOVEMENT:

Jump, dance, do pushups, stomp your feet. Get back in your body.

The grounding technique that works best for ME:

MY TRIGGERS & EARLY WARNING SIGNS

Triggers are things that remind your brain of the trauma:

My triggers (people, places, sounds, smells, dates, situations):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Early warning signs I'm getting triggered:

In my body: _____

In my thoughts: _____

In my behavior: _____

My plan when triggered:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

HEALTHY COPING vs UNHEALTHY COPING

No judgment. You survived however you could. Now let's find safer ways.

UNHEALTHY (makes sense but hurts)	HEALTHY (try these instead)
Self-harm	Ice cube, red marker, snapping rubber band
Isolating completely	Text one person, sit near others
Substances	Exercise, cold water, intense music
Risky behavior	Safe thrills: roller coasters, spicy food
Exploding at people	Journaling, punching pillow, running
Starving/bingeing	Eating one small thing, telling someone
Numbing out (screens 24/7)	10 min outside, grounding exercise

PROCESSING FEELINGS

Trauma can make it hard to know what you're feeling. Let's practice:

EMOTION WHEEL - Today I feel (circle all that apply):

Angry - frustrated - annoyed - rage - irritated

Sad - lonely - hopeless - grieving - empty

Scared - anxious - panicked - worried - on edge

Ashamed - guilty - embarrassed - worthless - dirty

Numb - disconnected - foggy - frozen - nothing

Happy - calm - grateful - hopeful - proud

Where do I feel this in my body? (check):

- ☐ Head/face
- ☐ Throat/chest
- ☐ Stomach
- ☐ Hands/arms
- ☐ Legs
- ☐ All over

BUILDING MY SAFE PEOPLE LIST

Not everyone needs to know everything. Different people for different needs:

Person I can talk to about ANYTHING:

Person who makes me laugh:

Adult I trust at school:

Person I can call at 2am:

Online community that gets it:

MY SELF-CARE MENU

PHYSICAL:

- Walk/run/dance
- Take a shower
- Eat something nourishing
- Sleep
- Stretch

EMOTIONAL:

- Journal
- Cry (it's okay!)
- Talk to someone
- Create art/music
- Watch comfort show

SOCIAL:

- Text a friend
- Sit with someone
- Join an activity
- Help someone else
- Hug someone safe

SPIRITUAL:

- Spend time in nature
- Pray/meditate
- Listen to meaningful music
- Practice gratitude
- Journal about purpose

WEEKLY CHECK-IN - Week 1

Date range: _____

Overall mood this week (1-10): ____

Times I was triggered: ____

Coping skills I used: _____

Something hard this week: _____

Something good this week: _____

Person I connected with: _____

Self-care I did: _____

Am I sleeping okay? ____ Eating okay? ____

One thing I'm proud of myself for: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN - Week 2

Date range: _____

Overall mood this week (1-10): ____

Times I was triggered: ____

Coping skills I used: _____

Something hard this week: _____

Something good this week: _____

Person I connected with: _____

Self-care I did: _____

Am I sleeping okay? ____ Eating okay? ____

One thing I'm proud of myself for: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN - Week 3

Date range: _____

Overall mood this week (1-10): ____

Times I was triggered: ____

Coping skills I used: _____

Something hard this week: _____

Something good this week: _____

Person I connected with: _____

Self-care I did: _____

Am I sleeping okay? ____ Eating okay? ____

One thing I'm proud of myself for: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN - Week 4

Date range: _____

Overall mood this week (1-10): ____

Times I was triggered: ____

Coping skills I used: _____

Something hard this week: _____

Something good this week: _____

Person I connected with: _____

Self-care I did: _____

Am I sleeping okay? ____ Eating okay? ____

One thing I'm proud of myself for: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN - Week 5

Date range: _____

Overall mood this week (1-10): ____

Times I was triggered: ____

Coping skills I used: _____

Something hard this week: _____

Something good this week: _____

Person I connected with: _____

Self-care I did: _____

Am I sleeping okay? ____ Eating okay? ____

One thing I'm proud of myself for: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN - Week 6

Date range: _____

Overall mood this week (1-10): ____

Times I was triggered: ____

Coping skills I used: _____

Something hard this week: _____

Something good this week: _____

Person I connected with: _____

Self-care I did: _____

Am I sleeping okay? ____ Eating okay? ____

One thing I'm proud of myself for: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN - Week 7

Date range: _____

Overall mood this week (1-10): ____

Times I was triggered: ____

Coping skills I used: _____

Something hard this week: _____

Something good this week: _____

Person I connected with: _____

Self-care I did: _____

Am I sleeping okay? ____ Eating okay? ____

One thing I'm proud of myself for: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN - Week 8

Date range: _____

Overall mood this week (1-10): ____

Times I was triggered: ____

Coping skills I used: _____

Something hard this week: _____

Something good this week: _____

Person I connected with: _____

Self-care I did: _____

Am I sleeping okay? ____ Eating okay? ____

One thing I'm proud of myself for: _____

MY HEALING JOURNEY MILESTONES

- | | |
|--|-------------|
| ☐ Acknowledged what happened to me | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Told someone I trust | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Used a coping skill instead of hurting myself | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Slept through the night | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Felt safe for a moment | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Went a day without being triggered | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Asked for help | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Set a boundary | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Felt a positive emotion | Date: _____ |
| ☐ Realized it wasn't my fault | Date: _____ |

RESOURCES FOR TEENS

Crisis:	Call/Text 988 Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741
Child Abuse:	Childhelp National Hotline: 1-800-422-4453
Sexual Assault:	RAINN: 1-800-656-4673 rainn.org
Trevor Project:	LGBTQ+ youth: 1-866-488-7386
Teen Line:	1-800-852-8336 (peer support)
Your Life Your Voice:	1-800-448-3000 (Boys Town)

Dear Me,